

Triads

A triad is a chord of a given note, a third, and a fifth. It consists of three notes, with two intervals of a third between the notes. The triad is the fundamental basis for making harmony in Western music.

SEE ALSO

◀ 56–59 Intervals

◀ 74–75 Modulation

Chord types 130–131 ▶

Chords 232–233 ▶

Tonic triads

A tonic triad is formed of the root, the third, and the fifth note of the scale in which it appears. The tonic is the name for the first note of a scale. B♭ is the tonic in B♭ major (and minor), and F is the tonic in F major and minor scales, triads, and chords.

root + third + fifth = triad



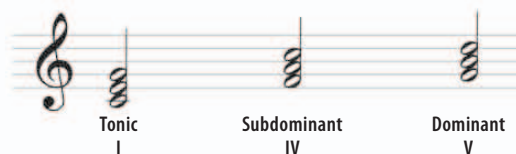
◁ Triad

The staff shows the triad as both an arpeggio and a chord. The triad is the chord built by placing the third and the fifth notes above the tonic so that they sound together.

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Triads in C major

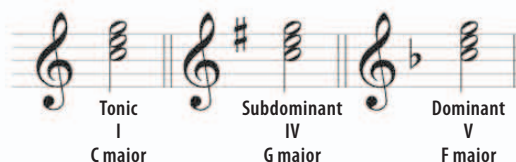
A tonic triad is built on the first note of a given scale (I), a subdominant triad is built on the fourth (IV, or subdominant) note of the scale, and the fundamental note of a dominant triad is the fifth (V, or dominant) note of the scale. These are the primary triads of any scale.



◁ Triads of C major

The three principal triads of C major are shown here. The interval between each note is a major third, or four half steps.

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◁ Triads with multiple meanings

The same triads can have multiple meanings depending on the chord they are in. So a C major triad may serve as I in C major, IV in G major, V in F major, etc.

LOOKING CLOSER

Arpeggios

Playing the notes of a triad separately produces an arpeggio. It is possible to make great music out of little more than chains of arpeggios, as Bach showed in the C major prelude that opens his sequence of

preludes and fugues in each key of the chromatic scale, known as *The Well-Tempered Clavier* ("clavier" is an old-fashioned word for a keyboard instrument).



◁ Bach's "Prelude in C major"

Trace the C major arpeggio from the Middle C in the bass clef. The entire prelude is built from these chains of thirds and fourths.